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Onaje Allan Gumbs

Onaje Allan Gumbs was born on September 3, 1949 in New York City. He attended the High School of Music and Art, and SUNY Fredonia, and quickly established himself as a composer and pianist after graduation. Onaje has worked with Norman Connors, Woody Shaw, and Nat Adderley, and he is currently active in the New York City music scene.

Onaje was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in New York City for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm pleased to have my old friend, Onaje Allan Gumbs with me today, who is a marvelous piano player and arranger and composer, and manages to make a life in music in New York City, which I think is saying something.

OG: Yes, yeah. That's kind of a mouthful. It's not the easiest thing to do. But one thing I learned early on, even as a teenager, was the ability to enjoy all genres of music. So jazz has always been my foundation. As a matter of fact my first real introduction to jazz was watching TV and looking at "Peter Gunn" and "Mr. Lucky," which was scored by Henry Mancini. So needless to say Henry Mancini had an integral part in my development as a musician and a music lover. And I used to go to every film he scored. And sometimes the films were horrible. But I mean I just had to go because I absorbed his music so much. I became kind of an expert on his musical style and his way with horns and how he used it dramatically in film. And from there I started listening to him on the radio, and from there I was introduced to Billy Taylor, because he was a DJ on a local radio station. He was on NEW, a station called WNEW, then he moved to a station called LIB, which is still happening right now but it's all R&B. They had like a whole jazz thing. So by listening to Billy and his roster of music, and the other two DJs that were on that same station, I got introduced to Dizzy and Gil Evans and Miles. This was like in the '60s, all these wonderful musicians. And I used to make a list — now mind you I'm all of like nine, ten, eleven years old — and I'm making a list of all these songs I heard on the radio that I liked. Like I've got to get that one, I've got to get that one. And my sister also had an impact on me because she had a very eclectic taste as a teenager. I mean most teenagers now would have one style of music in their repertoire. And at this time, like at sixteen years old, she had Barbra Streisand, Johnny Mathis, Igor Stravinsky, Sonny Rollins, Loretta Alexandria, Johnny Pacheco, you know it was just endless, of all these different — Nat King Cole, Nina Simone. So I would go down to the basement where all

realizing that I'd like to be a part of all this kind of music. So to shuttle between different styles of music was not a big thing for me, through high school I was playing with a Latin jazz band that was structured after Cal Tjader. The leader was a vibraphone player, the percussionist was Jerry Gonzalez of Fort Apache fame and his brother Andy Gonzalez. It was at the Music and Art High School in New York. And so I was at that band and at the same time I was working with one of my first mentors named Leroy Kirkland, who wrote "Cloudburst," I don't know if you know that tune.

MR: Sure.

OG: He wrote "Cloudburst," and he was also the arranger of a famous R&B tune called "Our Day Will Come," Ruby and the Romantics. So I became kind of his protégé. Because his son felt I should meet his father. And he lived right down the block from the school, so a lot of times after, instead of going home I'd go to his house. And he'd have me rehearsing with some of the singers that would come by the crib, he took me to sessions, I met Kenny Burrell through him, I met Jerome Richardson through him, because he was doing a lot of studio work, so all these guys in the studio. So I was in this whole world of these big guys you know. So again, with the big band — well the big band also — the Latin jazz band, doing duos, four hand piano with another keyboard player in the school, and doing the R&B thing, it just again contributed to this whole eclectic approach and love for all styles of music.

MR: Let me take you back for a minute, what led you to the piano, and was your family supportive of your music?

OG: Okay. I just recently got a story from my mother. She said — it's funny — she said when I was in my crib, you know the bar that would be on the crib, I'd be going like this—

MR: Oh, come on.

OG: She swears I was doing like this when I was a baby in the crib, just going like this, so she realized I had some musical talent. And I remember when I was three years old, this I remember, when I was three years old I would walk around the room singing "Oh My Papa," by Eddie Fisher.

MR: Really, Eddie Fisher.

OG: Yeah. Somehow I knew every word to that tune at three. Three years old. Now a three year old, you can imagine, a three year old singing an Italian song in Harlem you know. So anyway, we moved from Harlem it was like '57, we moved from Harlem to Queens. And it's funny because I felt like at seven years old I picked the house. And it turned out that there was a piano teacher right in that neighborhood that I could walk to her house from my house. They didn't know this. And the church, she was an organist, it was right down the block also. Everything walking distance. So we went to her house and I began

talents, because at Christmas time we'd have to prepare a concert for our families, because you know they'd have a big Christmas dinner, and afterwards fill their face, you know, come and hear little Allan play a little concert. So she helped all the students prepare these concerts. And with that she would have five Christmas cards on the piano. So she would say, "Well pick one that you like." So I looked and picked one that I thought was nice. I'd open it. And she'd say, "Okay I want you to set this poem to music." And that's how I started getting into composition. And along with my love for Henry Mancini, my composing talents started to develop. I never really studied formally composition. By the time I took any composition courses, I took an elective in high school and one in college, I'd already been doing it. And one thing about my composition technique, I never could follow strict forms. In other words, like following the sonata form or whatever. And I remember in high school my composition teacher in high school told me I would never become a good composer because I didn't follow the method to a tee. They used to say when I got to Fredonia, and I entered a contest where I had written a woodwind quartet piece—

MR: I remember hearing it.

OG: That you played on. Did you play on that?

MR: I don't think I played on it, I remember listening to it.

OG: Yeah, the woodwind quartet piece, I took first place. Well it was very interesting that one of the professors, Dr. Shields

MR: Richard, Shields, yeah.

OG: He came to the lunch room and said, "Allan won the contest, and it wasn't even jazz." Which was interesting because in going to Fredonia, that was kind of a culture shock.

MR: I was going to ask how you ended up there.

OG: Okay, what happened was that I had taken auditions for different schools. I tried Eastman, which I totally messed up. And Manhattan School of Music for some reason I took the theory, to be a theory major. And a student named David Butler had come down to the Music and Art and had talked up Fredonia. So there were about six of us from Music and Art, decided we'd look it up, you know, see what's up. So I had gotten my teacher because she never was really hot on like Bach. And somehow I felt like I needed to learn this composer, for some reason. I said I'd like to learn some Bach. And so we got into the inventions first and then the fugues. So here I am at the audition for Fredonia and I kind of aced everything, right. And see Bach, although I wanted to do it, I wasn't really comfortable with Bach you know. So I played everything thinking that would be it. And all of a sudden he says, "Do you know any Bach?" I said ahhh, why'd he ask me that question you know. Well I said okay I'll do my C minor fugue. And I just breezed

had already failed Eastman, I wasn't too happy about New York College of Music and Manhattan School of Music because I felt I'd see myself at the clubs all night with a midterm the next day. Because I'd probably be at the clubs watching Milt Jackson or Herbie, instead of studying for an exam. So I said I need to get out of New York. So I finished the audition and he says, "Well Allan, you know there aren't many black people in Fredonia." My thing was I really don't care, I want to know did I pass the audition or not.

MR: I'm surprised he said that.

OG: He said that, he said that. I'll never forget. Because he felt it would make a difference. Because here I am in the big city of Harlem — not a big city of Harlem — big city of New York, and I'm going to essentially a country town. You know I'll never forget because downtown Fredonia reminded me of a scene from "In the Heat of the Night." You know, just the opening scene of "In the Heat of the Night." You'd go downtown, if you ever see it, it looks like downtown Fredonia. Okay? So anyway but at that point that was the farthest from my mind. So I decided to say listen did I make it? You know I don't care about, you know. And he said yes. So I was happy. And of course the other five students also came to Fredonia so I felt good because the culture shock wasn't that great, because actually my first roommate was Warren Hargut, who was from Music and Art. So it was really cool. And he ended up being one of my last roommates, when we shared—

MR: Right, the house.

OG: Everybody, we shared a house together. So anyway it was cool but there was still this thing because I was drafted into the big band. You know, usually every situation you have to audition, you have to go through a whole process. And I have to admit it was very weird. Because I was called to the rehearsal and they said, "Well sit down at the piano and start playing." And they said well it's like, "You got the gig." I said, "Excuse me? I just got here." It was like not to make it seem too — I don't know how to put it — but it was almost like a situation where okay you're black, you're from New York, you play jazz, we need a piano player.

MR: Yeah, a bit stereotypical.

OG: It was like a stereotype. I don't want to go there but it seemed like that's exactly what's happening. And I was already talked up before I got there. So I said, "Wait a minute I just got here and I'm not sure." "It's okay, it's okay, you'll be fine." Needless to say I was in the band, again the only black musician in the whole band. Through that we did a festival at Villanova. And it was televised on PBS. And Gary McFarland watched it and wrote me a letter.

OG: And what happened, at that time we still had a faculty instructor. So in his infinite wisdom, not realizing he had broken all the laws of the postal service, Gary mailed me a letter, right? And it says Attention — you know if you get a letter Attention so-and-so, that is the person that's supposed to open that letter. And what happened is that the director, his name was Steve Wolczynski, he had introduced me on the air as "the piano player from The Queens." Because there's only one borough that says "the" before and that's The Bronx. For every other borough it's like Queens, Brooklyn, Manhattan, Staten Island. But you get to "The Bronx" you had "The Bronx." So he said "The Queens." So Gary thought that was real funny, because he said "Attention, piano player from The Queens." Well it came to the jazz department—

MR: Oh he didn't know your name.

OG: Yeah, he didn't know my name. Because—

MR: They didn't announce your name.

OG: Yeah they didn't announce it or it just went by real fast. Because we did a composition that I had written that I had never done arranging before either. So they helped me orchestrate this tune and we did it. And so he opened the letter. Not only did he open the letter, he Xeroxed the letter and put the letter on the bulletin board, so everybody could read this letter that was mailed to me. I'm in theory class and they say, "Allan, man" there was a guy, Joe Pizano I think his name was, "there's a letter for you on the bulletin board." I said, "What?" I go down and there's this letter from Gary McFarland. Now mind you I was excited but I didn't realize the fact that this man has broken all the laws and actually invaded my privacy, because the letter was addressed to me. And I met Gary McFarland, later I went down to New York. And he had had a record label called Sky Records. He, Cal Tjader and Gabor Szabo. Unfortunately all three of them have passed away. So even during school I was starting to get a taste of the professional world. And that kind of culminated with being connected with another person who has been a mentor to me, Billy Taylor. And I guess prior to that Herbie Hancock. Because I met Herbie when an advertising firm came to give a lecture at a job, an ad agency, and one of the people working there was a friend of my sister. So they thought I might like to attend this seminar about music in commercials. And they had shown a commercial, a cigarette commercial, and actually, this is a little trivia, it's "The Prisoner" by Herbie Hancock, the tune "I Have a Dream" was originally a cigarette commercial tune. It originally was a cigarette commercial. And it was great, I mean the tune is awesome, but that's where it started. That's where the gem started. But I went and met one of the people who were doing the lecture. I had a meeting with him and he thought I should meet Herbie. So I went to a concert that Herbie was doing in Central Park and introduced myself to him.

Herbie Hancock. Now mind you he's only like all of twenty something years old, but to me he was like this legend, and he's still in his twenties. But I got to know him and really it was an incredible situation, but while I was in college, Billy Taylor, Dr. Billy Taylor, afforded me the opportunity to arrange — compose and arrange — some music for a show he was the musical director of at that time, that was David Frost. And I had gone to him and said I'd like to write something for the show. And he said well come back in August. So I thought it was like a W.C. Fields line — go away kid, you're bothering me. So I came back and he said, "Well how soon can you write something?" And I was like oh damn, he really wants me to do it. So I wrote this arrangement, composed and arranged it, they copied it out professionally and everything. And I go back to school, and this is about the time we were at the house, in the senior year, I turn on David Frost every day, didn't hear my song. I said oh man, they don't like my music, wow. So anyway, next recess I go down to the studio and I said, "Man, what happened?" Well we had a little problem with your chart." So when I looked at the chart, I don't know what I was thinking, the first page, the trumpet part was on line 3, next page it was on line 4. I said, oh, we have a little problem over here. So we spent the time rehearsing and getting all the music together. We got it together. That day for every cue going to a commercial they played my song. I was like wow. It was great. Plus I was getting paid.

MR: Yeah. It's a good feeling.

OG: And then every time, because it was like a Brazilian tune, right. So I go back to school, so every time like a Latin guest, or a person from like Puerto Rico or Brazil or something, every time they introduced a guest like that, I remember Catarina Valente was one of the guests [scats] that's my tune. So I was like grinning you know. So going back again, Dr. Taylor and Leroy Kirkland and the next person that had an effect on me was Kenny Burrell. Because through Leroy Kirkland I met Kenny and I had given him a tape. And this was right after I got out of college. And I gave him this tape, of course it was a reel to reel, no cassettes them, big reel to reel, seven inch tape, all from college. Stuff that you played on. So I gave it to Kenny, it was on a Thursday night, Kenny said, "Okay, I'll give it to you on Monday." So I come home and my mother says, "You got a call from Kenny Burrell." This was Friday. I said, "Really?" "Yeah, he said call him back." So I said okay, so I'm in my mother's room sitting at the table, I could see it right now. I picked the phone up, I called, I said, "Kenny, this is Allan Gumbs." "You want a gig?" "What?" So, because I gave him a tape just as a composer and arranger. Because for some reason as much piano as I played, I never felt confident as a pianist.

MR: No kidding.

OG: I felt that somehow I wasn't up to snuff to be considered to be able to do that. As much as

in there. But he felt different. And I did my first major gig with Kenny Burrell in Detroit, at Baker's Keyboard Lounge. And from there I met Earl Klugh. And we became friends, and another saxophone player who still lives in the Detroit area, his name is Allan Burns, a tenor player. So I was started to get slowly acclimated into this whole professional situation.

MR: Was this after graduation?

OG: It was after graduation. Right after graduation almost. A few months.

MR: Did you have — when you graduated, most of us at the time, with a few exceptions, everybody was going to go out and find teaching jobs.

OG: Right.

MR: But that wasn't your intention was it?

OG: No. What happened is that my father, who wanted me to do this, called me into the dining room, sat me down, and said okay what are you going to do with your life?

MR: One of those questions.

OG: One of them questions. Because here my mother and my father said oh good he has a teaching degree he'll have something to fall back on, that kind of — and a few times before that he called me in and I really didn't know. I said I'm not quite sure yet. Finally this last time he called me in and I said, "I want to be a working musician, and I know how hard it's going to be, I know it's going to be tough, but that's what I want to do. I'm ready to deal with it." Little did I know — you know what I'm saying — that all your worries were true. But the thing is is that when I said that, because my father was the kind of person that, he may not agree with your decision but if you were sincere and convinced and determined to do something that he knew was at least going to try to bring some value he would support it. Because what happened is that of course in the time that we were graduating from Fredonia was in the middle of the Vietnam war. And they had a lottery system.

MR: I remember that. Do you remember standing in front of the TV and watching that thing come up?

OG: Yeah. And my number was 49. My number was up. So I was going to Vietnam. And I went through the whole thing of going down and the whole draft thing and taking the test, and couldn't bring myself to lie or do stuff that —

MR: Yeah, right.

OG: And of course they were ready to ship me off. But I decided I wasn't going. And I wasn't going to flee to Canada. So the only thing I had at my disposal was to plead a conscientious objector. And I used my music and my religion. Because that would be religious reasons. And I went through different anecdotes, going back to in high school

get in the middle of it because I valued their friendship, so it was always hard for me to draw sides and take sides. And I just did like this whole paper, it was like a thesis, about my feelings about war and feelings about killing people. And I had to have some people to write affidavits to support my feelings. And Dr. Billy Taylor was one of the people that wrote a letter. And at that time I didn't realize it, I found out maybe ten years ago, my mother had a trunk with some of my stuff in it, and actually he is the reason I chose the name Onaje. Because I found the name in a book of African names as "the sensitive one." And Billy wrote in print that Allan is a very sensitive person. And he went on to say, "He will be of no use to you." You know I guess his thing was he'll sabotage a mission, because the man is so against killing people that you'll have a hard time so you really don't want him. So he did it in a round about way of telling him, you don't want to sabotage your mission, so if you don't want to sabotage your mission you will not take him into the Army. Then it turned out that when I was in a band at that time, another band in Queens, and one of the managers was actually on the board, the draft board. And I did it fair and square. I mean I went up there, my father went with me, he is a World War II vet, the whole nine yards. But he supported the fact that I didn't want to go and why I didn't want to go, and he stood by me. And at one point they asked me, if someone harms your mother, would you retaliate? And I broke down and started crying. And I said no. And I remember I just couldn't contain myself, I just started to cry and cry and cry. Because even though I knew that my manager was on the draft board, not on that particular one but he was part of the whole draft board process, I still wanted not to be a shoo-in type of thing where he — I wanted them to know that I was sincere. So the only difference was the fact that instead of waiting two weeks, I found out that night that I got it. So I was given the 4F — no actually given — no the 4F classification, and I'm waiting to find out what this manager is going to do to keep me out of going, now that I got this deferment. Because usually you have to go work someplace that's so far away from your house you wish you had gone in the Army you know. And they make it very uncomfortable for you. You're usually working like in a mental institution or something like that. So around that time a friend of mine named Sabu, a great bass player named Sabu Adeola, who lived in Buffalo, who I met in my senior year at Fredonia, because one of the fellow students took me to Buffalo. I had never been to Buffalo.

MR: Really. All that time.

OG: I had passed through Buffalo but I'd never stayed in Buffalo. So I met some musicians during that time and he called me and said we have a program, we'd like you to teach, it's a Model Cities program. And it turned out that this program fit the requirements of a CO deferment. Because it had to be a nonprofit organization, more than fifty miles away from

me, I just started working. And they wrote the person who was in charge, Sabu signed a form, I had to send away to show what I was making and all that kind of stuff. So about six months later I get reclassified. So I'm relieved of my CO classification, but in other words you'll never be called. You don't have to do service anymore and don't worry about being called. But since I was working up there in Buffalo and getting paid, and going through this whole thing with the music and the culture and everything, I decided to stay. I could have left right then but I decided to stay in Buffalo. And I stayed there almost two years, where I also met my wife. And the benefit of that is that there is a club called the Revelot, and all the cats came through. All the cats came through. Herbie and Ahmad Jamal, Rahsaan Roland Kirk, Freddie Hubbard, Roy Ayers, George Benson, endless stream of musicians, Pharoah Sanders. And again that was where Buffalo was again a definite nourishing environment for me to develop some things I hadn't done before like my arranging and it afforded me the opportunity of meeting some of these great musicians on a one-on-one basis. Because the thing with the Revelot was that most clubs, if you do a week it's six days. You start on Tuesday and work through Sunday. Revelot has a very interesting policy. You started on Monday and you're off on Wednesday. And then you do a matinee on the following Sunday. And at the matinee you can come and sit in with the artists. You can sit in with Herbie Hancock, sit in with Rahsaan Roland Kirk, Freddie Hubbard, whoever. So that was pretty cool. So I had sown the seeds for the future by meeting all these cats that I was able to talk to and get to know what I would be doing in New York. And it was something that was really great. And one of the people again who was a mentor of sorts was Norman Connors. Because he came through with Pharoah, a week right behind Herbie and his group, and commissioned me to do the title track of his second album. Because I just approached him and said I can be the guy you want. Because he was looking for a certain type of arranger who could do strings and do a tune in Brazilian flavor. He just like hit two buttons with that. Because I was doing strings in college and Brazilian music was like my favorite. So from there he listened to, again, my tapes in college, and I got the gig. You know so that was my first major recording situation. And from there I went to work with him, about six months. So I've done about maybe five or six albums, and most notably was my arrangement of "Betcha By Golly Wow," for Phyllis Hyman, which launched her career. And I went on to be her musical director and recorded one more time with her. Well actually we did a whole album at the beginning of her career and then two years later I did one song called "The Answer is You." And again this whole eclectic thing was happening. I was still going between straight ahead cats and R&B cats and so there is one thing that I really feel is really important in the music is that we get further away from being so concerned about

emotional response — emotional responses, although in varying degrees, from being very subtle to almost like crazy. But still the emotional responses are pretty much the same, whether it's adulation or whether it's a joy or sadness, a tear, jumping up crazy, whatever, a big smile on your face, whatever. It's a fact that whether Samuel Barber "Adagio for Strings" or John Coltrane doing "Greensleeves" or Duke Ellington doing "Satin Doll," or Aretha Franklin doing "A Natural Woman," you know, or Al Green doing "Let's Stay Together," okay or Jimi Hendrix doing "Hey Joe," the emotional response is still the same. And we spend so much time separating the music. I think jazz is the music that is the foundation for everything to me. Because I feel that a jazz musician has instinctively more eclectic taste than a rock musician or a classical musician or a country & western musician. Most of the composers in the sixties for Universal Studios especially were primarily jazz musicians. Benny Golson, Benny Carter, Quincy Jones, Oliver Nelson, Lalo Schifrin, Neal Hefti, Gil Melle, Henry Mancini, Nelson Riddle, Marty Paich — all jazz musicians. We didn't see Aaron Copland in there Okay? We didn't see Earl Scruggs. You know, whatever. We didn't see, but we heard classical music. We heard jazz. We heard Rock.

MR: They could write anything.

OG: They could write anything you see. So I felt good about that I was part of that community that had, again, those eclectic tastes. And so I just wanted to continue that. My big idol when I was a teenager was Herbie. Because again, the fact that he was with Miles and then doing all these like CTI, and them dates, with Wes Montgomery and people like Paul Desmond. I said I want to do that. That's what I want to do. He's playing all this hip stuff over here and then working with Miles, and then doing his own albums. That's what I wanted to do. But I also made a decision that I wanted to be a producer. I wanted to be a songwriter. I wanted to be a pianist, okay, I wanted to be an arranger. Okay? And I haven't done a whole host of things as compared to somebody like Randy Brecker or Herbie. But the body of work that I've done I really feel proud of, for the fact that it's been recognized and it's stood the test of time. So in '86, I'm moving along right over some stuff.

MR: You talked about Woody Shaw?

OG: Yeah, oh yeah, I've got a whole back down. What happened with Woody, which prior to Woody I was with Nat Adderley. Nat had just formed a group after Cannonball died. And of course you know that Nat and Cannonball came to the college.

MR: Yes, I do, I remember I had to play in front of them.

OG: And what we had to do to get them there. You didn't know that.

MR: I was not hip to what was going on with that.

OG: It was very political. Because they were going to do a three day seminar. The whole seminar was going to cost five thousand dollars. Then it went down to four thousand dollars. Because it was something that the students were going to kind of do. It wasn't something that was put together by faculty. Students had got wind of this educational thing that Cannonball was doing and they felt we needed to get that. And it's a great story man. It's unbelievable too, I'm surprised you don't know everything that went down. Because we got back from vacation, summer vacation, and one of our fellow students John Luebke was organizing this and asked me to come on board. I said great. So they got the numbers together and we had approached the Union Board of Governors to give us the money. They thought well why should we give you money for something that's going to only benefit the music students. Because this was everybody's money. Okay we can't just give you separate money if the English majors can't benefit from it, and the physics majors can't benefit from it, and the speech therapists, you know, how can we give you everybody's money just for your own little thing? So what we want you to do, we want you to go to every chairman of each department and get a letter saying that Cannonball Adderley's presence on this campus will benefit their department. Chemistry. Physics. History. My thing was fine. Not a problem. And I went to the English department. I went to the Dance department, I went to every department on that campus and we all got letters. Here. Okay? Then they say well he can't come. What? Cannonball, it seems they can't show up.

MR: Cannonball what?

OG: They can't make it. Then all of a sudden it changes, he can come. But he can only come for one day. What? Then it changes, he can come for both days. So by the time Cannonball got to the campus we tried to question him about all this stuff. He said "well they told me to come for one day." Okay. So I didn't want to make a whole big thing or anything, but it's something that kind of found a little spot in my brain, I found out about the attitude of the school. But moving ahead again, after college, the whole thing, then moving to Nat, because that's when I really got to know them, Nat had formed a band. And I was asked by a very good friend and drummer Buddy Williams, to come into the band. And I also had met a bass player whose last name was the same as mine, Gumbs, Fernando. So I called him to audition on bass. So he got the gig so we were both in the band. And I stayed in the band for about maybe a year. What I learned with Nat was the importance of engaging the audience, which his brother was a master of boy. And it was so incredible to see how he was able to have the audience in the palm of his hand. And it stayed with me, as it has stayed with people like George Duke, who went through Cannonball's band. And again we were in there for a while and then we broke up.

and the Basic Black Band. Because Nat didn't feel like doing all the road work, all the little stuff like the renting of the truck and all this kind of stuff. So he put that in our laps. But we got tired of it after a while. So that's when he disbanded as a band, realizing he had to come back on board and take charge. Because we liked it for a while, and then we got kind of tired of it so we went to Nat and said listen, can we have a talk? So we had a band meeting. And that's when he decided I'm going to dismantle this band. But I was at a club and Woody Shaw was in the club. He had a way of talking, oh this gruff little voice. And he says, "You want to join my band?" "What?" "You want to join my band?" I loved him as a player, because he was one of the baddest cats. But I wasn't too crazy about him, you know, I wasn't sure I wanted to work with him you know. So I said, "Well who else is in the band?" So he says, "Well Victor Lewis is on drums, and Carter Jefferson is on tenor and Clint Houston." "Cool, yeah, okay." I loved those guys, so if nothing else I'll have some great cats to work with, if I can't even stand Woody. But it turned out to be one of the most incredible experiences. And Woody became a friend as the years progressed, only maybe two years. During that time Woody had done an interview and commented about the members of the band. And it got to me. And he said, "You know Onaje is to me as Gil Evans is to Miles." I said oh, oh, okay. I still have to find that article, because I lost it somewhere. It was a *DownBeat* on microfilm or whatever. But the other thing that really blew my mind is when he got the deal with Columbia Records. And he was going to do an album called "Rosewood." And he said "Onaje, I want you to arrange this tune. Just do it." Okay. So I took it upon myself to arrange a tune, no running interference, I didn't have to show him what I did to get his approval, I just did the tune. And it was like the title track of his first major deal, Columbia Records. I didn't put it together. Rosewood. You know it's like a tree or something like that? Later on down the line it turned out that it was a song that was dedicated to his parents. Because his mother's name is Rose and his father's name was Woody. So Rose-Wood. And I felt really honored. Because this is something, this is an homage to your parents, who gave birth to you, and you want somebody that's not in the family, to actually bring your sentiments to your parents alive. Wow man. I mean still to this day it's something that really touches me as far as the confidence he had in me and the faith he had in me to bring it through. The break-up of the band was hard, or him firing me was difficult here but I was able to handle it so to speak. Because he called me up one day and says, "I think you forgot who the leader of the band is, I don't like your attitude, and I want my music back. You got anything to say?" "No." Nothing. And that was it. And a few years later we hooked up again, because it couldn't last, because we had some history. And I guess the unfortunate thing of that whole thing was that two of

MR: He had a terrible accident, didn't he?

OG: He had a terrible accident where he was invited by Max Roach to come to the Vanguard. He was staying with his parents. The limo came to pick him up. Now this is kind of sketchy because I'm getting all this second hand. The limo comes, picks him up, brings him to the Vanguard. He's going around the club and he's kind of loud and the club ain't but that big. So they decided he needs to be sent home. He gave the limo driver a hard time coming, so the limo driver said listen, I'm out of here, you take care of him. So they had to get him a cab. But no one went with him. He went by himself. So he commandeered, I think he commandeered the cab to a location he wanted to go to. All right? What happened in between that I really don't know because only Woody knows. Next thing you know he is on a railroad track. The train comes in the station and goes over his arm. And he is in trauma, and I think they amputate the arm, and a few more weeks of that, he finally succumbed. And then Carter Jefferson was in Europe or Poland. And he had a problem with his liver or something like that. He took sick. The promoters thought he was high on drugs. There was no ambulance, they had to put him in a cab and drive him miles to the hospital. And they left him on the front step. Because they didn't want to be hooked up with this. You know what I'm saying? They didn't want to be a party to a possible drug situation.

MR: Right, in a foreign country and the whole thing.

OG: But it was actually his liver or something. And so Carter died. And then not too long ago, Clinton, the bass player, it's all the original Woody Shaw band, he passed away. So it was like Victor and I still holding up doing what we need to do individually. But that was one of the most incredible musical experiences, and to me Woody, and I'll say this with no kind of censorship or any kind of limitations, Woody was probably the last major innovator on the trumpet. There are others who play now who are good. But as far as bringing a certain passion. Because his eyesight — you know a lot of times if someone has a certain kind of tragedy or a certain kind of situation as a musician it transfers into the music. And he being legally blind, which I know is something that really must have ate at him okay, I think it came out as passion in the music. And another thing that of course I have no idea of knowing but I think because of his eyesight being so bad, he couldn't write tunes out a lot. So he relied on the band members to bring tunes to the book. So you had a very democratic situation, to the point that he would dog Carter to no end, because Carter wouldn't put a tune into the book. He dogged him for about a year. And finally Carter brought this tune into the book. And we did a rehearsal at the Vanguard and I don't know if you've ever had this experience but hearing a small group and in the small group you could actually hear the orchestra. Okay? To me a tune that

comes to mind is "Blue Rondo a la Turk" by Dave Brubeck. Especially the middle part [scats].

MR: Oh yeah. Good example.

OG: You can hear an orchestra doing this. Carter brought this tune in called "Rise from Atlantis." It had the same effect on me. I could hear the horns. I could hear the strings. I could hear the percussion. I mean it was an awesome tune. So Carter, I says, this was well worth the wait, you know, for your not contributing any music in this band. And we had a couple of anecdotes with Woody that were priceless. Because we were asked to do a tribute to Mingus when Mingus passed away. At Carnegie Hall. And of course the traditional thing, when you pay homage to a fallen soldier, you play his music. Well at the rehearsal Woody says, "I ain't playing no Mingus music." We say "Woody" — you know my brain is going man— He says "if they don't want to hear my music that's too bad. I'm playing my music." That's not the point, we're supposed to — so what happened, I had to think quick. Because I'm part of this band, so whatever he does, I'm part of it. So I said well I've got to do something. I'd written this tune, which served both purposes. It helped keep him doing his band music, yet still pay homage to Mingus. I'd written this tune called "You Never Said You Had Go." And he presented it in that context, as to why I'd written this music, just for Mingus. I remember — my wife doesn't remember this but I talked about it and she was at the concert. She said she started crying for the sentiment of the tune. Because Mingus died kind of suddenly. So that's why I said "You Never Said you Had to Go." So I was like wheew, man, to get out of that one. Because at the rehearsal I was like oh sh— I can't say that word right. And we got through it, we got through that. But you know more recently I've really been trying to just enjoy all the music, and enjoy everything that's out there.

MR: Tell me what a typical week is like for a musician like yourself in New York.

OG: For me? Watching Jerry Springer. No. Sometimes it's like that for a musician, you know, watching TV. A good week is getting calls from different people. A good week is hooking up a session with somebody, getting a call to go to Lebanon, getting a call to go to Japan. I haven't written as much in recent years. I used to write music every day in high school. What's happened now is that a lot of my old stuff is being recorded now.

MR: Oh wow.

OG: Stuff that I wrote when I was fourteen, fifteen years old, is now being recorded. I present this tune to a person, oh, it's a great tune. You know Vanessa Williams — Vanessa Williams — Vanessa Rubin, I produced her first album. Her first two albums. And she did a song of mine that I wrote when I was fifteen years old. The lyrics were written much later, but the song itself was written when I was fifteen. I played it for her, she

reviewer somehow thought that my tune was a standard. He said well Vanessa recorded the standards, "Got the World on a String," "Tenderly," "Autumn" blah-blah. I said "Autumn," that's my song. First recording of the song. But he thought it was a standard, which made me feel very good. Because one thing that — you may get disagreement from people — but one thing that bothers me is that a lot of the cats now are not writing the new standards.

MR: I've often wondered that. Where are they going to come from?

OG: You know, we're still doing "Stella By Starlight" and you know, all these tunes, as great as they are, whether it's "I Remember Clifford" or whatever, the reason they wrote these tunes, Benny wrote "I Remember Clifford" — he didn't want to play what was done thirty years before that. You know. And it's good to have in the repertoire, but understanding the momentum, you know, in other music people are constantly writing new songs, in country & western music and everybody's constantly writing new tunes. And new tunes that people can sing, they can really listen to. Somehow jazz takes again this classical approach. Like how many times are you going to do Beethoven's Ninth? How many times are you going to Carmina Burana? How many times are you going to do Puccini aria from whatever? Okay? And the new music is usually an exercise in how many notes can I get in between two measures? How slick can I make the chord progression? And one thing that bothers me is the lack of engagement of the audience. Because one of the things that jazz does not share with the other more popular music of the day, mainly rap, R&B, pop, whatever, is that audience participation is part and parcel of the presentation. It's what makes the whole presentation come alive, is actually the response of the audience to the music. In jazz it's about a quiet policy, and a polite applause between solos. You see? And that's it. And okay we don't have a problem with that. But short of that, can't you at least talk to the audience? Can't you like let them know what you're playing? Or maybe who wrote it? You see? It doesn't happen.

MR: See that comes, I think your sensitivity to that also is partly due to the fact that you do write, you know, so that you feel like composers should be acknowledged when they get their pieces played, and that's on target.

OG: Yeah. I mean I heard a concert where Buster Williams was playing. And he has this incredible piece called "Christina." It's one of the most beautiful ballads you ever want to hear. But he was a side man in this one group. They did it. You didn't know the name of the song, let alone know that Buster wrote it. And I think in a room full of people it might be nice to know that it wasn't written by a piano player, it wasn't written by a horn player, but this beautifully harmonically intricate song was written by the bass player who happens to be on the stage right now. How do we get to know our new composers?

he's a great composer at the same time. And this bothers me in the music. The lack of concern for the audience. And you don't have to become shuckin' and jivin' all kinds of stuff, but just engage, to communicate. I remember Stephon Harris who is one of the brightest young vibraphonist musicians out there. I remember going to his gig. And he was getting ready to announce the song and he couldn't remember the tune. And he played it up. He had everybody cracking up. Because he's getting ready to play the song, he doesn't even know the title of his own tune, and everybody's like cracking up in the club, which is part of the whole thing. And then he said, "I got this other tune I wrote, and you know something, I don't have a title for it so I'll tell you what, if any of you have a good idea for a title, please let me know." Do you know people came up to the stage and said, "Stephon, I got the title for you man." You know it was great because you were engaging the audience. Okay? We don't have to go jumping around, everybody's not going like hey, all right. You know? You don't want that. But still in talking and communicating, because what happens is, this is my own feeling, what happens is that when you go to see a musician play, you come away with one or two things. "Man he was bad man, hey man, he plays his butt off." Or "he was kind of sad, you know, I wasn't really feeling him." To me that's very one or two dimensional at best. You don't know whether they have a sense of humor, you don't know whether they have kids, they're married, if they have any views. Which many times you see so many songs, like especially like say during apartheid, you get all these songs, "Johannesburg," "Soweto," "Tutu." But no one talked about the inspiration with these songs. You know it just became a tune that showed that they knew what was going on in the world. But not so much to have any thought about it. Just that it made them current. Well why don't we hear some views that you have about South Africa? About apartheid? Okay? We don't do that. And a lot of musicians did and still do talk, engage, that's what Cannonball did, Duke did, Louis Armstrong did, Barry Harris does. Okay? There are a lot of musicians who do talk. Frank Foster does, okay. So it's not an indictment against all of us. But there are enough of us that do not engage the audience that just makes it like one dimensional.

MR: That's good advice to heed.

OG: Because you'd like to know something about the person. Because see again, a theory I have, that's why talk shows were invented, for the actors. Because you see an actor on stage, or in a film, he's playing someone from the eighteenth century, and someone from the twenty-fifth century in another film, and he's a good guy in this film and he's a bad guy in that film. Okay. But you don't know nothing about the person. So my own theory is that that's why the talk shows came in. Because now you can see this actor that you've seen on screen or on stage and get to know what he's like. Is he married? You know,

having. Okay I think this dialogue helps to do that but there's not enough of it. Okay? And we have the opportunity even on stage to do that. And most of us don't take that opportunity. And also, because the fact that it is a primarily instrumental medium it makes us less accessible. Because all the other genres are vocally driven. That's one thing I think we have to understand as jazz musicians, as opposed to man, well rock musicians get this and the Pop musicians get this, and the R&B musicians, and how can rap and hip hop rise so much? Because they are vocally driven and based on this stage presence and everything like that. Jazz is not built around that, with the exceptions of the greats Ella, Sarah, Joe Williams, Billy Eckstine, recent Diana Reeves, Cassandra Wilson, Kevin Mahogany. But that's a very small percentage of the entire jazz community, which are primarily saxophone players and guitarists and horn players, you know. So until we get to that point where we feel that we need to really reach out, jazz is always going to remain in a stereotypical, inaccessible mode. As long as we try to intellectualize the music to a point where it's above everybody's head.

MR: Yeah. Exactly.

OG: Well at the same point you can play music for a little five year old and they'll start dancing. Until we bring it off of the lofty stools that there are, and heights, because we're trying to offset the juke joints that the music thrived in. But whoever goes to Lincoln Center or Kennedy Center, the music you're playing at Kennedy Center was played at those juke joints. So putting it behind a different building doesn't change the music. If it's elevated enough to be considered for the Kennedy Center then it was always elevated. Regardless of where they —because sometimes maybe that's all the place they had to play the music. Okay? You can't condemn the music because you see it in a juke joint or see people boozing or on drugs. Okay? Or of equating jazz musicians with being drug users, as though no other profession does it. So no one can convince me that the person that works in the stock market is not on drugs. Okay? All that yelling and screaming when the stock market changes. You've got to be on something. But they don't get condemned.

MR: Listen, what's in the near future for you, we're going to have to wrap up here.

OG: I have two projects. I did a "Live at the Blue Note" which I'm very proud of. And I finally did a Henry Mancini tune, I talked about earlier on. I had never done Henry Mancini in my book. So I did "Dreamsville" from Peter Gunn. And did more piano. Because I was always behind the scenes, getting the saxophone player up there, the trumpet player, but now I'm doing the front line. I have a studio project I did on my own with some great people on it, that I'm trying to bring out independently. I'm working on a concert with the great singer Carmen Lundy to fashion a thing called "The Art of

high schools, colleges, to talk about the relationship between the pianist and the vocalist, on all different kinds of levels. And the preparation needed from both. I've done some acting. I acted in a play, a professional production of a play called "Lady Day at Emerson's Bar & Grill," and I play Lady Day's pianist, Jimmy Powers. I had a few lines, but it was still a whole new kind of experience. So that's something I may even check out a little more. And I'd like to do some more scoring. I did a film for Danny Glover in '94 for Showtime, so that experience was something that has opened me up also. But the eclectic approach that I learned from being very young is something I'm going to continue, not just as a solid jazz pianist, although I hate the word "jazz." I hate the word "jazz" because so many things go with it that have connotations, okay? But in lieu of a better term to come down the pike, as a solid jazz musician. But also to be involved in other sincere expressions, which may take me to Latin, Brazilian, hip hop, R&B. To me if you are a serious musician about what you're trying to do, I don't care what you're playing. Because we can communicate. Because we're doing something that a whole lot of people were doing, accounting and Internet can't do, and that's really play notes, bring these notes together, and move people without words. Everybody can't do that or else everybody would be a musician. You see? So that's what I want to do. And finally to get my name to be something that people will say — well who was that? Or when's he coming out with something? No, I've got something new out, I've got something current out, I'm who I am and I want to finally, for 2001 set the record straight, and not to be confused with Najee.

MR: Oh, please. Oh geez.

OG: That's happened. It hasn't happened recently but I went through a whole period, believe me, trust me. It was really for pictures, pictured together with tee shirts—

MR: No kidding.

OG: That says "I'm not Najee," and his says "I'm not Onaje." You know.

MR: Well I never had to do that with Thelonious Monk.

OG: Oh yeah a lot of people ask you where you got that from.

MR: They do. Well listen, this has been really fascinating, I'm so glad we ran into each other here, and I bet this is going to be a good year for you.

OG: I'm determined for it to be a good year. You know? So I appreciate your having me.

MR: All right, thanks so much.

OG: Thank you.